

MILLAR'S WAR

Changing the game and having an impact isn't easy. We speak to Mark Millar, the creator of the bestselling comic of the last decade, about its origins in *X-Men*, facing-off our favourite heroes and having his work turned into billion dollar franchises



Millar has see many of his storylines adapted by Hollywood.

The phrase 'game-changing' is bandied around a lot when it comes to the stories that we consume. Some introduce a new way of thinking, some kick-start a new genre, while others simply propose the unthinkable. In the case of Mark Millar and Steve McNiven, they pit two of Marvel's biggest heroes against one another – and this time there is actually a consequence to the smackdown.

The story in question is the *Civil War* arc from the minds of Mark Millar and Steve McNiven, which is the basis for one of this year's biggest blockbusters. The original story sees the introduction of the Superhero Registration Act, following an explosion in Stamford caused by Nitro. All superheroes must sign or face the consequences. Naturally, that doesn't go down too well with a large number of the heroes, and a fight ensues. It sees Steve Rogers' Captain America facing up against Tony Stark's Iron Man in what have become some of the most recognisable images in comic history.

Interestingly, the original concept wasn't meant for the Avengers, in fact, it was meant to spark a rift between two very different heroes: "It started life as an idea I had for *X-Men*," writer Mark Millar tells us. "They wanted me to revamp *X-Men* and I had a plan to move the Xavier/Magneto quarrel forward a generation and have a new split in the mutants after Xavier is killed and Cyclops and Wolverine fall out. I wanted to do a big ideological argument, but at the same time have a lot of fun with heroes fighting heroes. I planned to do this for 2007, but Marvel needed a summer crossover for their other characters so I just transplanted the idea into the heart of the Marvel Universe. *X-Men: Civil War* became *Civil War*. I still planned to write the *X-Men: Civil War* book at that point, which is why Marvel's most popular characters of the time didn't really appear in *Civil War*, which seemed odd to people"

And so it was that the idea was transplanted onto Tony Stark and Steve Rogers, two individuals who have always shared different views on the world. One is an upstanding soldier, defined by his righteous personality and his patriotic views. Stark, on the other hand, started as a man consumed by desire for fame and fortune before becoming a hero; he's plagued by his past mistakes and is desperate to do right because of it. The other heroes split between the two of them, with Spider-Man starting off on Stark's side before eventually defecting to the side of keeping his identity a secret, which is something Peter Parker